

The Grammar of Work

Target Groups, Objectives, Results, Products, Activities and Actors

Organisations are rarely short of activity. They are often short of clarity.

They know which departments exist, which processes have been documented, which systems support the work and which responsibilities appear in the organisation chart. Yet three basic questions often remain difficult to answer.

What is a service?

What is a product?

Who actually does what?

These questions matter because organisations depend on services and products. They use them to organise work, assign responsibility, design processes and decide what should be governed. Yet the terms are often used without a shared meaning.

A department may be called a service. An activity may appear in a service catalogue. A process, system or team may receive the same label.

A report may be called a product even when it only records an analysis or decision. A completed activity may be treated as proof that something useful has been provided. A result may be named without explaining which products are needed to realise it.

The organisation may appear orderly while the relationships that give its work meaning remain unclear.

This is not merely a problem of language. It is a problem of organisational arrangement.

When services and products are not defined clearly, responsibility becomes difficult to assign. People may know that they are involved without being able to state what they contribute. Departments may complete their part of a process without knowing what another actor requires from them. Managers may create controls and reports without first making clear what should be controlled and why.

More information does not resolve this problem by itself. Neither do more process diagrams, ownership models or dashboards. Insight and governance depend on services and products that have first been arranged coherently.

Consider Meridian Group, a fictional company that has made a serious effort to describe its services.

Its service catalogue contains familiar entries such as Customer Onboarding, Data Validation, Case Assessment, Approval, Reporting and Communication. Every entry refers to real work. Departments know which entries relate to them, and managers know which processes they oversee.

THE GRAMMAR OF WORK

The catalogue appears clear until Meridian asks what each service actually provides.

Customer Onboarding is described as registering a new customer. Data Validation is described as checking submitted information. Case Assessment is described as reviewing a case. Approval is described as deciding whether a request may proceed.

These descriptions are not wrong. They describe work that takes place. But they describe activities. They do not yet define services.

They do not always say for whom the work is performed. They do not clearly distinguish what is provided from what the service seeks to realise. They may name the actors involved without explaining what each actor contributes.

Meridian can see that work is taking place, but it cannot yet see how the work forms a coherent service.

The Grammar of Work offers a way to make these relationships explicit.

Work becomes explicit when actors are connected to the activities they perform and to the products those activities form. A target group gives the service its orientation. An objective expresses what the service seeks to achieve. The intended result makes that objective concrete by describing the condition the service seeks to realise.

The architecture can be read through three modes: design, execution and evaluation.

In design, actors interpret the situation of the target group, formulate the objective and intended result, determine what products are required and arrange the activities and actors needed to form them.

In execution, actors perform those activities, form and provide products and through those products realise all or part of the intended result.

In evaluation, actors compare proposed or provided elements with the criteria that govern them and form assessments or determinations about whether they correspond.

These are not different directions of one relationship. They are different kinds of relationship.

Design establishes what is required. Execution forms and provides it. Evaluation determines whether the design and execution correspond with the conditions of the service.

Design, execution and evaluation all follow the same grammar. Actors perform activities through which recognisable products are formed.

The products of design and evaluation belong to the work through which a service is arranged and assessed. They are not automatically products that the operational service provides to its target group.

The centre of the service lies between product and result.

The product is what execution provides. The result is the condition that the service intends to realise through that provision.

A product realises all or part of a result. The result determines what the product must enable.

A result may contain several conditions that together describe what must become true. Making those conditions explicit does not add another element to the architecture. It clarifies the content of the result so that the products it requires can be determined and evaluated.

This distinction changes how an organisation can define and arrange its services.

Customer Onboarding is no longer understood simply as registering a customer. Registration may form a customer record, but that record is only one product. The service may also require an approval decision, an activated account, configured access and a confirmation message.

THE GRAMMAR OF WORK

Different actors may form these products through different activities. Together, the products are intended to realise a condition in which the new customer is ready and authorised to use the relevant services.

Meridian can now begin with more precise questions.

Who is the target group? What does the service seek to achieve for that group? What result would make that objective concrete, and what must be true for that result to count as realised? Is the content of that result coherent? Which products does the result require, and is that product set complete and sufficient? Which activities must form those products? Which actors can perform those activities? Does execution provide what design specified?

These questions shift attention away from the structures the organisation already has and towards the service it needs to provide.

The service catalogue no longer needs to be a list of things the organisation does. It can become an explicit account of what the organisation provides, for whom it provides it, what that provision is intended to realise and who performs the work.

This paper develops that account step by step. It defines a service, separates product from result and explains how the two relate. It shows how design moves from target group towards actors, how execution moves from actors towards the intended result and how evaluation tests the important points of correspondence. It introduces six prime activities through which work can be described more precisely. It also shows how one service can use products provided by another service.

Meridian Group accompanies this development throughout the paper. Its Customer Onboarding service is gradually opened and arranged until the service, its products and the contributions of its actors become explicit.

The purpose is not merely to produce a clearer description. The purpose is to provide a sound basis for organisational design, insight and governance.

When the arrangement is explicit, the organisation can see what is required, what is provided, how it is formed, who contributes it and whether execution corresponds with the result the service intends to realise.

1. What is a service?

The word service is used generously in organisations.

A department may be called a service. A process may appear in a service catalogue. A system, team, responsibility or activity may receive the same label. The organisation may believe that its services have been defined while it has only renamed the structures and work it already had.

This matters because the word service implies provision. Something is provided for someone, and that provision is intended to realise something.

Calling an activity a service does not yet explain for whom the work is performed, what is provided or what the provision is meant to achieve.

A service is therefore more than an activity. It is also more than a product, department, process or system.

A service is a purposeful arrangement in which actors perform activities, form and provide one or more products, and through those products realise a result for a target group.

This definition contains six elements.

THE GRAMMAR OF WORK

The target group is the group for whom the service exists. It gives the service its orientation.

The objective expresses what the service seeks to achieve for that group. It guides the formulation of the intended result and provides a basis for judging whether that result is the right one.

Objectives and evaluation criteria give direction to service design. This paper makes their role in the service arrangement explicit; it does not establish where an objective or criterion derives its authority, who may set it or where it applies. Those grounds and authority belong to the applicable governance arrangement and should remain explicit there.

The result makes the objective concrete. It describes the condition that the service intends to realise for the target group.

Products are the direct outcomes formed through activity. They are what the service provides and the means through which the result can be realised.

Activities are the work through which those products are formed.

Actors are the people, teams, organisational units, organisations or systems that perform that work.

Together, these elements explain for whom the service exists, what it seeks to achieve, what should become true, what must be provided, how it is formed and who performs the work.

When one of these elements remains unclear, part of the service remains unclear as well. Useful work may still be taking place, but it has not yet been arranged as a complete service.

The examples in this paper describe a service with one target group, objective and intended result. This is the working scope of the examples, not a claim that every real arrangement has exactly one of each.

Where distinct target groups or intended results require different product contracts or accountability, represent those variants explicitly. Whether they form one service or several is a design decision based on the arrangement, not simply the number of conditions within Result.

Meridian reopens Customer Onboarding

Meridian originally described Customer Onboarding as registering a new customer.

Registration may form a customer record, but the existence of that record does not show whether the customer has been verified, approved, authorised or given usable access.

Meridian therefore begins with the target group: new customers who need access to Meridian services.

This gives the service its orientation. Meridian can now express its objective: to enable new customers to begin using the relevant services correctly and securely.

The objective guides the formulation of the result. Customer Onboarding seeks to realise a condition in which the new customer is ready and authorised to use the relevant services.

Meridian can also test this result against the objective. If the customer is ready and authorised, the result advances the objective of correct and secure use. If the result merely stated that a customer record exists, it would be too narrow. It would not yet make the objective concrete.

The result can then be stated precisely enough to show what must be true for it to count as realised. The identity and relevant information of the customer must be sufficiently established. Permission must have been granted. An operational account and the required access must be available. The onboarding outcome must have been made available to the customer.

These statements do not create another element between Result and Product. They make the content of the result explicit. The result, understood in this complete form, determines which products are required.

THE GRAMMAR OF WORK

The service may need a verified customer record, an approval decision, an activated account, configured access and a confirmation message. Each product contributes something different.

The verified customer record provides reliable information about the customer. The approval decision establishes whether the customer may use the relevant services. The activated account gives the customer an operational identity. Configured access enables actual use. The confirmation message makes the outcome known.

These products must be formed through activity. Customer information must be examined and recorded. Relevant conditions must be assessed. A determination must be formed. An account must be created. Access must be configured. The outcome must be communicated.

Those activities require actors.

Customer Administration may form the verified customer record. A manager may form the approval determination. Account and access management systems may create the account and configure access. Another actor may make the outcome available to the customer.

Whether the approval determination is valid or binding depends on whether the actor has the authority required by the arrangement. Authority does not determine whether a determination has been formed. It determines the status of that determination within the service.

Customer Onboarding is now visible as more than registration. It is a purposeful arrangement in which several actors perform activities and form products that contribute to one intended result for a defined target group.

A service is not an organisational structure

Customer Administration may contribute to Customer Onboarding, but the service is not identical to the department.

A department describes where actors are located within the organisation. A service describes what is provided, for whom it is provided and what result that provision is intended to realise.

One department may contribute to several services, and one service may require contributions from several departments. A service therefore does not have to follow the boundaries of the organisation chart.

The same applies to teams, roles and systems. They may perform work within a service, but they do not define the service by themselves.

A service is not a process

A process describes how work progresses. It may show order, dependencies, decisions and transfers between actors.

A service answers a different question. It describes what is provided, for whom it is provided and what the provision is intended to realise.

The process may change while the service remains recognisable. Activities may be reordered, automated or assigned to different actors without changing the target group, objective, result or required products.

A process can support the execution of a service, but it does not define the service.

A service is not an activity

An activity describes what an actor does.

THE GRAMMAR OF WORK

A service places that activity within a wider arrangement. It explains why the activity is performed, which product it forms and how that product contributes to an intended result.

Registration is an activity. Customer Onboarding is a service.

Verification may be an activity within Customer Onboarding. Identity Verification may also be a complete service when it has its own target group, objective, result, products, activities and actors.

The name does not determine whether something is a service. Its arrangement does.

A practical test

Whenever Meridian describes something as a service, it can ask six connected questions.

Who is the target group?

What objective gives the service direction?

What result should the service realise, and what must be true for that result to count as realised?

Which products does that result require?

Which activities form those products?

Which actors perform those activities?

The third question makes the content of Result explicit. It does not introduce a seventh element. Each stated condition should be necessary, and the conditions together should be enough to recognise the result as realised.

Meridian can then keep the later tests distinct. It can assess whether the product set covers the complete result, whether the specified products can collectively realise it and whether execution provides the products that were specified. It can also evaluate whether the identified target group and objective are clear, whether the result advances the objective, whether the activities can form the required products and whether the actors can perform those activities under the required conditions.

When these questions can be answered coherently, the service becomes clear.

When they cannot, the organisation may still be looking at a department, process, system, responsibility or activity that has been given the name service without yet being arranged as one.

The definition of a service therefore does more than provide a label. It gives the organisation a basis for deciding what the service is, what it must provide and how the work should be arranged.

2. Design, execution and evaluation

A service can be understood through three modes.

Design establishes the required arrangement. Execution performs the work and forms the products.

Evaluation tests whether proposed or provided elements correspond with the criteria that govern them.

These modes belong to the same service, but they do not describe the same relationships or the same moment.

They are also forms of work. Design, execution and evaluation are performed by actors through activities that form recognisable products.

Design

Design begins with the target group.

THE GRAMMAR OF WORK

The target group is the reference point of the service. Design identifies and describes that group and gives the service a clear orientation.

The objective expresses what the service seeks to achieve for the target group. It guides the formulation of the intended result.

The result makes the objective concrete by describing the condition that the service seeks to realise.

A result may be a compound condition. Design makes its content explicit by stating what must be true for the result to count as realised. These statements remain part of the result. They do not form a separate element or an additional step in the architecture.

Once the result is clear, designers determine which products it requires, which activities must form those products and which actors must be able to perform those activities.

The design movement can be read as follows:

Target Group guides Objective.

Objective guides Result.

Result requires Product.

Product requires Activity.

Activity requires Actor.

These statements do not imply that design happens by itself.

Actors observe the situation, relate needs and conditions, interpret what they mean, formulate objectives and results, determine requirements and make the arrangement explicit.

The products of design may include a description of the target group and its boundaries, an objective, an intended result stated with sufficient precision, product requirements, activity requirements, actor requirements and the arrangement that connects them.

An element of the service can therefore also be a product of the work through which the service is designed. The roles are different. The result is an element of the service being arranged, while its formulation is a product of the design activity. This does not add elements to the service architecture.

Design products belong to the work that creates or changes the service arrangement. They are not automatically part of the product set that the operational service provides to its target group.

For Customer Onboarding, Meridian identifies new customers who need access to its services as the target group. It formulates the objective of enabling correct and secure use. It then defines the intended result as a condition in which the customer is ready and authorised to use the relevant services.

Meridian makes that result explicit by stating what readiness and authorisation require. The result, in that explicit form, requires several products. Those products require activities, and those activities require actors with the necessary capabilities and working conditions.

Design therefore moves from what the service seeks to realise towards the arrangement needed to support it. It does not begin with the departments or systems Meridian already has.

Execution

Once the service has been arranged, execution moves from actors towards the intended result.

An actor performs an activity. The activity forms a product. The product realises all or part of the result.

The execution movement can therefore be read as follows:

Actor performs Activity.

THE GRAMMAR OF WORK

Activity forms Product.

Product realises all or part of Result.

Execution may involve many operations. Someone may read, compare, calculate, consult or enter information while performing an activity. These operations explain how the work is carried out. The product shows what the activity must bring into being.

Execution may also depend on products formed by other actors or services. An approval determination may require a verification finding. Account creation may require that approval. Access configuration may require an activated account.

These dependencies do not change the basic grammar. Actors perform activities. Activities form products. Products contribute to the intended result.

Evaluation

Evaluation examines whether an element corresponds with the criterion that governs it.

It can be applied to every design relationship.

The identification and description of the target group can be examined for clarity, scope and relevance. The objective can be tested against what matters to that target group. The result can be tested against the objective. Product requirements can be tested against the result. Proposed activities can be tested for whether they can form the required products. Proposed actors can be tested for whether they can perform those activities under the required conditions.

The target group itself is not a result that the service seeks to realise. It is the reference point of the service. The design product is the identification and description of that group, and that design product can be examined and revised.

Evaluation is itself work.

An actor compares what is proposed or provided with a criterion, relates the two, interprets whether they correspond and may form a determination when a binding conclusion is required.

The product of evaluation may be an assessment, interpretation, recommendation or decision.

Evaluation products belong to the work through which the service is assessed. They are not automatically products provided by the operational service to its target group.

For Meridian, an activated account may be evaluated against the requirements implied by the onboarding result. The account may exist, but evaluation may show that it belongs to the wrong customer, lacks the required permissions or became available too late.

The same applies to the proposed activity and actor. Evaluation may show that the selected activity cannot form the required account or that the selected actor lacks the capability, capacity or authority needed under the arrangement.

Evaluation can also examine the result itself. If Meridian defined the onboarding result merely as the existence of an activated account, evaluation against the objective would show that the result is too narrow. An account that exists does not yet mean that the customer is ready and authorised to use the relevant services.

These evaluation questions concern different objects and should not be collapsed. Evaluation may test the internal content of Result, the completeness and sufficiency of the required product set, or the correspondence between a provided product and its requirement. A failure in one test does not establish a failure in another.

The modes do not form a process chain

Design, execution and evaluation use different relationships.

Design establishes what is required.

Execution forms and provides what was arranged.

Evaluation tests the proposed arrangement and what execution provides.

They do not need to occur only once or in a fixed order. Evaluation may lead to changes in the description of the target group, the objective, the result, product requirements, activities or actors. Execution may reveal that a product cannot be formed under the stated conditions. Design may then need to be revised.

The architecture therefore describes a coherent arrangement rather than a fixed sequence of steps.

A diagram may show only the two central evaluation relationships to preserve readability. This does not mean that evaluation is limited to those points. Every design relationship can be examined.

3. What is a product?

The word product often suggests something physical that can be held, stored, transported or sold. That meaning is too narrow for understanding work in organisations.

A product may be material, digital, informational, organisational or institutional. An observation, interpretation, decision, recommendation, message or realised state can all be products.

What matters is not whether the product is tangible. What matters is that something has been formed through activity and can be distinguished from the activity itself.

A product is the direct outcome formed through an activity. Its existence makes the completion of that activity recognisable.

From activity to contribution

Organisations often describe work by naming activities.

People analyse information, review cases, make decisions, configure systems and communicate outcomes. These descriptions show that work is taking place, but they do not yet show what the work has produced.

A person who says, "I have been analysing," describes activity. A person who provides an analysis makes the outcome of that activity visible. A technician may work on access for several hours, but the contribution becomes clear only when the required access state has been configured.

Activity describes what someone does. Product describes what that activity brings into being.

A meeting may have taken place, a process may have been followed and considerable effort may have been invested while it remains unclear what has been provided. Being active is not the same as producing something.

The product therefore provides a practical test of completion: what now exists because the activity was performed?

An analysis activity is complete when the required analysis has been formed. A decision activity is complete when a determination exists. A configuration activity is complete when the required state has been realised. Communication is complete when the intended content has been made available to the intended recipient.

THE GRAMMAR OF WORK

An activity may involve many operations. Analysis may require observation, comparison and interpretation. Decision may require evidence, consultation and consideration. These operations explain how the work is performed. The product states what the activity must bring into being.

Making the product explicit also makes the contribution of the actor clearer. Actors may attend meetings, exchange information and take part in several stages of a service. Participation alone does not show what each actor contributes.

Once the product is known, the organisation can determine what was formed, who contributed to it, who depends on it and under which conditions it must be provided. Responsibility can then be connected to a recognisable contribution rather than to a broad area of involvement.

Several actors may contribute to one product, and one actor may form several products. The product remains the common point around which those contributions can be understood.

The role of a product depends on the arrangement

The same thing can occupy different roles in different arrangements.

A defined result can be a product of design work and an element of the operational service that has been designed. A verification finding can be a product of Identity Verification and a required contribution within Customer Onboarding.

This does not make the concepts interchangeable. The role is determined by the arrangement being examined.

When the operational service is examined, its products are the outcomes it forms and provides in order to realise its result. When the design or evaluation of that service is examined as work in its own right, the design or evaluation also has actors, activities and products.

The grammar can therefore be applied recursively without adding elements to the service being described.

Provision and acceptance

A product is provided when it has been made available to the intended recipient under the required conditions.

That does not automatically mean that the recipient understands it, agrees with it or uses it.

Those later conditions belong to the result only when the service has explicitly taken responsibility for realising them.

Customer Onboarding may be responsible for making a confirmation available to the customer. It does not automatically guarantee that the customer reads or understands every part of it.

When formal acceptance is required, acceptance can be described within the same grammar. The recipient or an authorised representative acts as an actor and forms an acceptance decision, confirmation or another recognisable product.

A separate acceptance layer is therefore not required. Acceptance is either outside the service result or is represented as a product formed through activity.

Products can take different forms

A sensor may form an observation. An analyst may form an interpretation. An architect may form a model. An adviser may provide a recommendation. A manager may form a decision. A system may create an account. A technician may realise a configured environment.

THE GRAMMAR OF WORK

These products differ in form, but each is the direct outcome of activity.

Some products are recorded or presented through documents and systems. The carrier should not automatically be confused with the product.

A decision may be recorded in a letter. An interpretation may be presented in a report. A relation may be represented in a model. The letter, report or model preserves or communicates the product, but it is not always identical to it.

The decision, interpretation or relation is what was formed. The document is the form through which it is recorded or made available.

This distinction matters because organisations often identify documents more easily than contributions. A report may contain several products, or it may present a product formed elsewhere. Naming the document does not necessarily explain what the activity has produced.

Meridian makes the products explicit

Meridian originally described Customer Onboarding as registering a new customer.

Once the service was opened, it became clear that registration forms only one part of what Customer Onboarding must provide. The intended result also requires an approval decision, an activated account, configured access and a confirmation message.

Meridian can now state what each actor forms and provides instead of saying only that several departments are involved.

The actor performs the activity. The activity forms the product. The product makes the contribution recognisable.

The product should not be confused with the complete result of the service. An activated account does not by itself make a customer ready and authorised to use Meridian services. It contributes one necessary part.

The product is therefore the point at which activity becomes a recognisable contribution to the service.

When the same state appears in more than one service arrangement, describe its role in each arrangement. Configured access can be a product provided by Access Configuration and a required contribution to Customer Onboarding. It is not, by itself, the complete Customer Onboarding result. The relation under examination, rather than the noun alone, establishes whether a state is represented as a product, a condition of Result or both in separate arrangements.

Without a product, it remains difficult to determine whether an activity is complete or what an actor has contributed. Once the product is explicit, the organisation can see what has been formed, what has been provided and where responsibility for that contribution belongs.

4. What is a result?

A result is the intended condition that a service seeks to realise for its target group.

The word intended is important. Work can have many consequences, but not every consequence belongs to the service. The result is the condition around which the service is deliberately arranged.

From objective to result

A result receives its direction from the target group and objective of the service.

THE GRAMMAR OF WORK

The target group gives the service its orientation. The objective expresses what the service seeks to achieve for that group. The result makes that intention concrete by describing what should become true.

For Customer Onboarding, the target group consists of new customers who need access to Meridian services. The objective is to enable them to begin using the relevant services correctly and securely. The result is a condition in which the customer is ready and authorised to use those services.

The objective and result are closely related, but they are not the same.

The objective expresses direction. The result describes the condition that the service seeks to bring about.

The objective also provides a basis for evaluating the result. A result is suitable when its realisation would advance the objective for the target group.

An objective may remain broad enough to guide several possible results. The organisation must therefore interpret which result best makes the objective concrete while remaining within the reach of the service.

For Meridian, the existence of a customer record would not be a suitable onboarding result. It would represent one product, but it would not yet advance the objective far enough. A condition in which the customer is ready and authorised is a better result because it makes correct and secure access concrete.

The movement from objective to result is therefore not merely a change in wording. It is an act of design, followed by evaluation.

A result can contain several conditions

A result does not always consist of one simple statement. It may contain several conditions that together describe the intended state.

Customer readiness and authorisation, for example, require reliable customer information, granted permission, an operational account, configured access and communication of the outcome.

Making these conditions explicit opens the content of Result. It does not insert another element between Result and Product.

The architecture remains:

Result requires Product.

The result, stated with sufficient precision to show what must be true, determines which products are required.

A result is explicit enough for design when every stated condition is necessary to the intended state and the conditions together are enough to recognise that state as realised. This tests the internal content of Result. It does not test whether products have been specified, whether those products are capable of realising the result or whether execution has provided them correctly.

The result explains why products matter

A product states what has been formed through activity. A result explains what that product is intended to make possible.

An analysis may contribute to insight. A recommendation may support a course of action. A decision may provide clarity. Configured access may enable someone to use a service.

None does so automatically.

The product must exist before it can contribute to the result, but its existence alone does not establish that the result has been realised.

THE GRAMMAR OF WORK

For Meridian, an activated account is a product. The customer being ready and authorised to use the relevant services is part of the intended result. The account contributes to that condition, but does not realise it by itself. The customer must also be approved, the correct access must be configured and the outcome must be communicated.

The result gives these products a shared purpose. It explains why they belong to the same service and what their combined contribution is intended to accomplish.

A result is not every consequence

A service can have consequences that extend beyond its intended result.

A customer who receives access may use the service successfully, use it poorly or never use it. A report may lead to action, discussion or no response. A decision may create clarity, disagreement or further questions.

Such consequences may be important, but they are not automatically part of the result of the service. Some depend on later decisions, other services or circumstances outside its reach.

Customer Onboarding does not need to guarantee that a customer will use every Meridian service successfully. That would make the result dependent on behaviour and circumstances the onboarding service cannot reasonably control.

The result can instead be defined as the customer being ready and authorised to use the relevant services. This goes beyond the existence of an account, but remains within the contribution that Customer Onboarding can seek to realise.

Use may create further effects or benefits for the target group, but those should not be silently added to the result. They belong to another service, another arrangement or a wider context unless the service explicitly takes responsibility for them.

The architecture therefore does not require a separate value element. The result describes the condition for which the service is arranged. Further benefit arising from use may matter, but it is not automatically part of that result.

A useful result is neither a vague ambition nor an unlimited promise. It describes a condition that matters to the target group and that the service can seek to realise through its products.

The target group provides the reference point

The same product may contribute to different results for different target groups.

A verification finding may allow the onboarding service to continue. The same finding may provide a compliance actor with assurance that the required checks have been performed.

A confirmation message may give a customer clarity about the outcome. For Meridian, the same message may provide evidence that the outcome was communicated.

The product may be the same, while its meaning differs because the target group and objective differ.

A result must therefore always be understood in relation to the group for whom the service exists and what the service seeks to achieve for that group.

Result belongs to the service

The product is the direct outcome of activity. The result is the intended condition that the service seeks to realise through one or more products.

THE GRAMMAR OF WORK

No single actor is necessarily responsible for the complete result. Each actor contributes through products. The service brings those contributions together around one intended condition.

The result is therefore the shared reference point of the service. It explains why the products are needed and what their combined contribution is intended to make possible.

5. Correspondence, completeness, sufficiency and responsibility

Product and result meet at the centre of the service.

The result requires products with particular properties. Execution forms and provides actual products. Evaluation determines whether what has been provided corresponds with what the result requires.

The result must be explicit enough to show what must become true, but its stated conditions remain part of Result. They do not require products independently. The result, as made explicit through its own content, requires the products.

Required and provided products

The result implies which products are required and what those products must enable.

Execution determines which products are actually formed and provided.

A coherent service requires correspondence between the two.

An activated account may exist without meeting what the onboarding result requires. It may belong to the wrong customer, lack the required status or be unavailable at the required time.

The organisation must therefore ask more than whether a product exists. It must determine whether the product has the properties needed to establish or support the relevant part of the result.

This comparison does not begin with blame.

An actor may have performed the activity correctly and formed exactly the product requested. The problem may lie in the arrangement. The product requirement may be wrong or incomplete. The selected activity may not be capable of forming the required product. The actor may lack the capability, capacity or authority needed under the stated conditions.

Evaluation identifies where the difference arises.

Completeness

A required product set is complete when every condition stated in the result has one or more specified products assigned to it and every included product has an explicit contribution to the result.

Completeness is therefore a test of coverage within the design.

A gap exists when no product has been specified for something that must be true for the result to count as realised.

An unexplained product exists when a product is included even though its contribution to the result is unclear.

Suppose Meridian specifies a verified customer record, an activated account, configured access and a confirmation message, but no approval decision.

The product set is incomplete.

THE GRAMMAR OF WORK

The result includes the condition that permission has been granted, but no product has been specified to establish that permission. The absence of the approval decision is therefore a gap in completeness.

Sufficiency

Completeness does not prove that the specified products can realise the result.

A required product set is sufficient when the specified products, if formed and provided with the required properties and under the stated conditions, are collectively capable of making the complete result true.

A set may be complete but still insufficient.

Meridian may, for example, specify a recommendation as the product intended to address the requirement that permission has been granted. Every stated condition of the result now has a product assigned to it, so the set is complete as a design map.

However, a recommendation does not establish permission. It cannot make the authorisation part of the result true. A valid approval determination is required.

The product set is therefore complete but insufficient, and the product requirement has been specified incorrectly.

The distinction is precise.

When no product is specified for something that must be true, the product set is incomplete.

When a product is specified but cannot make that part of the result true, the product set is insufficient or incorrectly specified.

Completeness asks whether every condition stated in the result is covered by the design.

Sufficiency asks whether the products can collectively realise the complete result.

These tests do not remove judgement from service design. They make the judgement explicit and open to examination.

Meridian can state which condition within the result each product addresses, why every product is included and why the complete set is considered capable of realising the intended result.

Correspondence in execution

Completeness and sufficiency concern the required product set established during design.

Correspondence in execution concerns what is actually formed and provided.

A product may be correctly specified but incorrectly produced. It may be incomplete, inaccurate, late or unavailable under the required conditions.

Evaluation first compares the product actually formed and provided with its requirement. It then considers whether that product can contribute as intended to the result.

This distinction prevents a failure of execution from being confused with an error in design, and prevents a design error from being blamed on an actor who formed exactly what was requested.

Keeping the tests distinct

The architecture distinguishes four tests. The content of Result is coherent when every stated condition is necessary and the conditions together are enough to recognise the intended state. The required product set is complete when every condition is covered and every specified product contributes to the result. It is sufficient when the products, if formed and provided as specified, can collectively make the complete

THE GRAMMAR OF WORK

result true. Execution corresponds with the design when the products actually formed and provided meet their requirements and can contribute as intended.

These tests answer different questions. A defective formulation of Result is not an incomplete product set. An incomplete or insufficient product set is not an execution failure. A correctly specified product that was formed incorrectly is not a design error. Evaluation should identify which test failed before responsibility is assigned.

Evaluation is work

Determining the coherence of Result, completeness, sufficiency and correspondence in execution is itself work.

An actor relates a proposed or provided element to the criterion that governs it, interprets whether they correspond and may form a determination about acceptance, rejection or adjustment.

The product of that work may be an assessment, recommendation or decision.

The same grammar applies when an organisation determines whether something is a service. An actor examines the proposed arrangement, interprets whether its elements and relationships are present and may form a determination about how the service should be defined.

Evaluation is not a seventh prime activity. It is a mode in which activities such as relate, interpret and decide are performed.

The same is true of design. Formulating a result, determining requirements and arranging activities and actors are activities performed by actors that form design products.

The grammar therefore applies to the design, execution and evaluation of the service itself.

The products of design and evaluation should not be confused with the products that the operational service provides to its target group. They belong to different applications of the same grammar.

Responsibility

Making these relationships explicit creates a clearer basis for responsibility.

An actor can be responsible for performing an activity and forming and providing the required product.

Design actors can be responsible for the descriptions, objectives, results, requirements and arrangements they formulate.

Execution actors can be responsible for the products they form and provide.

Evaluation actors can be responsible for the assessments and determinations they form about correspondence, completeness and sufficiency.

The service as a whole can be considered in relation to the result it intends to realise.

The complete result may depend on several products and several actors. Assigning it entirely to one actor would hide those dependencies. At the same time, an actor cannot point only to effort or completed activity when the required product has not been formed.

The product remains the clearest point around which responsibility for contribution can be organised. It shows what an actor must form and what the service depends upon.

Responsibility becomes clearer when the design products, required products, provided products, evaluations and intended result are all explicit.

6. Products, activities and actors

A service rarely consists of one actor performing one activity and forming one product.

An intended result may require several products. A product may require several activities, and several actors may contribute to its formation. One actor may also perform activities for several products or services.

The organisation of a service becomes visible when the intended result is connected to the products, activities and actors required to realise it.

Patterns of contribution

For Meridian, the onboarding result requires several products. Each contributes something specific, and the result depends on their combined contribution.

The relationship does not need to be one product to one activity or one activity to one actor.

A verified customer record may require information to be collected, examined, compared and recorded. Customer Administration may form part of the record, while an Identity Verification service provides a verification finding and information systems provide existing customer data.

An approval decision may depend on the verified customer record and other information. A manager forms the determination, but other actors have contributed the products on which it depends.

The same actor may also contribute to several products. A customer administrator may help form the customer record and later make the onboarding outcome available to the customer.

These relationships create a pattern of contribution. Products may depend on other products. Actors may contribute to several products. Several actors may be needed before one product can be completed.

The architecture remains the same within that pattern. Actors perform activities through which products are formed and provided. Those products contribute to the intended result.

Making this pattern explicit prevents the organisation from reducing the service to a department, process or broad collection of work. It shows which contributions are required and how they depend on one another.

Design from result towards actors

A coherent service is designed by beginning with what it intends to realise.

Meridian first identifies the target group and objective. It then formulates a result that makes the objective concrete and tests whether that result is suitable.

The result is stated precisely enough to show what must be true for it to count as realised. This opens the content of Result without adding another element to the architecture.

The result then determines which products are required. Each product leads to the activities required to form it. Each activity leads to the actors, capabilities and working conditions needed to perform it.

For Customer Onboarding, Meridian begins with the intended condition that the customer must be ready and authorised. It then makes clear what readiness and authorisation require.

Reliable customer information must be available. Permission must be granted. An operational account must exist. The correct access must be configured. The customer must be informed that onboarding has been completed.

The result, understood through these statements, requires the products the service must provide.

THE GRAMMAR OF WORK

The products require the activities through which they can be formed.

The activities require the actors able to perform them.

This order matters.

When an organisation begins with its existing departments or systems, it tends to define the service around what those actors already do. The result is often a catalogue of activities rather than a coherent arrangement for a target group.

Beginning with the intended result changes the question. Meridian does not ask how existing departments should be fitted into Customer Onboarding. It asks which contributions the onboarding result requires and which actors are best placed to provide them.

Existing structures remain relevant, but they no longer determine the meaning of the service. They are assessed in relation to the products and activities the service requires.

This may reveal gaps, overlapping responsibilities or activities that do not contribute to any required product. It may also show that Meridian needs another actor, a different activity or support from another service.

Design from result towards actors does not prescribe a fixed organisational form. It provides a basis for determining which arrangement can support the intended result.

Execution from actors towards result

Once the service has been arranged, execution moves in the opposite direction.

Actors perform the required activities. Through those activities, products are formed and provided. The products contribute individually and together to the intended result.

Execution may involve handovers and dependencies, but the service should not be understood merely as departments passing work to one another. What matters is how each contribution supports a required product and how those products support the intended result.

A delay in one product may prevent another product from being formed. An incomplete verification finding may prevent a valid approval decision. A valid approval decision may exist while account activation remains outstanding. Configured access may be available while the customer has not yet received confirmation.

These dependencies become easier to understand when the organisation follows products rather than broad activities or departmental involvement. Meridian can see what is missing, which contribution depends on it and which part of the result cannot yet be made true.

The same view makes boundaries clearer. A department may contribute to several services, and one service may use actors from several departments. The department is an organisational unit. The service is the purposeful arrangement that connects contributions to an intended result.

Organisational design should therefore follow the pattern of required contribution rather than assume that existing structures already represent coherent services.

This does not mean that every service needs a separate department or dedicated actors. Actors may be shared, systems may support many services and one product may be used by several services. The organisation must nevertheless be able to identify which activity an actor performs, which product that activity forms and which part of the result the product supports.

Evaluation and adjustment

Evaluation can be applied to every relationship established during design.

THE GRAMMAR OF WORK

Meridian can examine whether the target group has been identified and described clearly and whether the objective addresses what matters to that group. It can test whether the result advances the objective and whether the wording of the result is precise enough to show when it has been realised.

It can then examine whether the required product set is complete and sufficient, whether the selected activities can form those products and whether the selected actors can perform those activities under the required conditions.

If a provided product does not correspond with what the service requires, the difference may arise at several points.

The content of the result may omit a necessary condition, include an unnecessary condition or remain unclear. A required product may be missing or incorrectly specified. The activity may be unsuitable. The actor may lack the necessary capability, capacity or authority. Execution may also have failed to form the product that was correctly arranged.

Evaluation makes these possibilities visible.

The purpose is not to treat every difference as an execution failure. It is to identify which part of the design, execution or evaluation requires adjustment.

Design itself remains work. Actors formulate results, determine requirements and arrange activities and actors. These activities form design products that can be evaluated and revised.

By reading the architecture from the result towards actors, Meridian can design the required arrangement. By following it from actors towards the result, Meridian can understand execution. By evaluating each important relationship, Meridian can determine whether the arrangement is coherent and where it needs to change.

7. The six prime activities

Organisations use many verbs to describe work. They manage, support, process, handle, coordinate, assess and administer.

Such words may indicate an area of involvement, but they do not always reveal what the work must bring into being.

The service architecture requires a more precise connection between activity and product.

An activity is identified by the product that is necessary for its completion, not by every operation that occurs during its execution.

An actor may read, compare, calculate, consult, enter data and attend meetings while performing an activity. These operations explain how the work is carried out. They do not necessarily identify the activity itself.

When the required product is a determination, the prime activity is to decide. When the required product is an interpretation, the prime activity is to interpret. The operations may vary, but the relationship between activity and product remains stable.

The six prime activities do not correspond one to one with the six elements of a service. They are two separate classifications. The six service elements describe the arrangement. The six prime activities describe basic ways in which products are formed.

THE GRAMMAR OF WORK

The three modes are also separate from the prime activities. Design, execution and evaluation describe the role that work plays in relation to the service arrangement. Observe, relate, interpret, decide, make and communicate describe the basic ways in which products are formed within those modes.

Six forms of activity

Six prime activities describe the basic ways in which actors form products: observe, relate, interpret, decide, make and communicate.

Throughout this paper, activity is the general work performed by an actor. The six prime activities name recurring types of work by the product they form. A particular occurrence is an activity instance that forms a particular product. The six types therefore do not imply six stages, teams or departments.

Observe forms a registered observation. An actor notices, detects or establishes something and records what was observed so that it becomes available as a product. A sensor may register a temperature, an employee may record that a document was presented, or a system may register that an event occurred. Merely seeing or sensing something is not enough. The observation becomes a product when it has been formed in a recognisable and available way.

Relate forms an explicit relation. It connects objects, observations, concepts, recipients or states so that their relationship becomes recognisable. An actor may relate a payment to an invoice, a person to a customer record or a permission to an account. The elements may already exist, but the relation between them is the product of the activity.

Interpret forms meaning or significance. Observations and relations do not always explain themselves. An actor interprets them to establish what they mean in a particular context. Customer details may be interpreted as sufficiently reliable, a pattern of events as a risk indicator, or a difference between records as a relevant discrepancy. The product is not the information itself, but the meaning formed from it.

Decide forms a determination. A decision establishes what will apply, what is permitted, what is required or which course will be followed. It may be supported by observations, relations and interpretations, but the determination is a distinct product.

Authority does not determine whether a determination has been formed. It determines whether that determination is valid or binding within the arrangement.

A person without the required authority may still form a determination. The arrangement may simply not recognise it as a valid approval or binding decision.

Make forms or realises an object or state. The product may be physical, digital, organisational or institutional. An actor may create a document, establish a customer record, activate an account, configure access or repair an installation. In each case, something is brought into existence or changed into the required state.

Communicate makes content available to an intended recipient. The product is not simply a message as an object, but the availability of its content to that recipient under the required conditions. An actor may publish a decision, provide instructions, send a confirmation or make information available through a system.

Communication is complete when the intended content has been made available to the intended recipient under the required conditions. Whether the recipient agrees, acts or fully understands may belong to a broader result, but it is not automatically part of the communication product.

These activities are not fixed stages in a process. They may occur in different orders, repeat or depend on products formed through other activities.

THE GRAMMAR OF WORK

An interpretation may require observations and relations. A decision may depend on several interpretations. Making an account may depend on a prior determination, while communication may be required at several points.

A single period of work may therefore contain several prime activities. What an organisation calls analysing may involve observing facts, relating information and interpreting their significance. What it calls processing may involve deciding, making and communicating.

The broad label describes an area of work. The prime activities reveal the products that must actually be formed.

Design and evaluation use prime activities

Design and evaluation are modes, not additional prime activities.

When an actor designs a service, the actor may observe the situation, relate needs and conditions, interpret what they mean, decide what should apply, make the arrangement explicit and communicate it.

When an actor evaluates correspondence, the actor may relate the proposed or provided element to a criterion, interpret the difference and decide whether it should be accepted or changed.

Design and evaluation may therefore contain several prime activities, just as analysis or processing may. What distinguishes the modes is not a new type of activity. It is the role those activities play in relation to the service arrangement.

Meridian identifies the activities

Meridian previously described Customer Onboarding through broad expressions such as registering a customer, performing checks, setting up access and notifying the customer.

These descriptions were understandable, but they concealed several forms of activity.

Customer details and submitted evidence must first become registered observations. Relevant identities, records, services and permissions must be connected through explicit relations. The significance of the available evidence must be interpreted.

An actor then forms an approval determination. The validity of that determination depends on whether the actor has the authority required by the arrangement.

Customer records, accounts and access states are made or brought into the required condition. Finally, the onboarding outcome and relevant instructions are made available through communication.

This does not require Meridian to divide the work into six departments or six consecutive process stages. One actor may perform several prime activities, while one activity may be performed by different actors or systems.

What matters is that each required product can be connected to the activity through which it is formed.

The distinction also improves the description of automated work. A system may observe an event, relate records, apply an interpretation, form a determination by applying authorised rules, make an account or communicate an outcome.

Automation changes the actor and the operations. It does not remove the need to identify the product or the authority under which a binding determination is formed.

Meridian can therefore examine any broad activity label by asking what product is necessary for its completion. If the answer is unclear, the activity has probably not yet been described precisely enough. If several different products are named, the label may conceal several activities.

THE GRAMMAR OF WORK

The six prime activities connect work directly to what it forms. They allow the organisation to see what must be done, what completion means and which actor contributes each product.

8. Services using services

A service does not need to form every product on which its result depends. It may use products provided by other services.

Customer Onboarding may depend on identity verification, account creation, access configuration and communication. Meridian could arrange all of these contributions within Customer Onboarding, but it could also obtain some of them from other services.

This does not change the definition of a service. Each service remains a purposeful arrangement of target group, objective, result, products, activities and actors.

A service can use products provided by other services while each service retains its own arrangement.

A product can connect services

The product formed by one service may become a required contribution within another service.

An Identity Verification service may provide a verification finding. Customer Onboarding uses that finding when forming the verified customer record and deciding whether onboarding may continue.

Account Provisioning may provide an activated account. Access Configuration may provide configured access. Customer Onboarding brings these products together around its own intended result.

The services are connected through their products.

This connection should not be confused with one service becoming an activity inside another. Identity Verification is not merely an onboarding activity when it has its own target group, objective, result, products, activities and actors. It is a service that provides a product on which Customer Onboarding depends.

A product can therefore cross a service boundary without the two services becoming one service.

For Identity Verification, the verification finding is a product formed through its execution. For Customer Onboarding, it is a required contribution.

The providing service remains responsible for forming and providing the agreed product. The receiving service remains responsible for how that product is incorporated into its arrangement and contributes to its intended result.

The correspondence between required and provided product therefore also applies between services.

Customer Onboarding must make clear what verification finding it requires. Identity Verification must make clear what it can provide and under which conditions.

When these do not correspond, the dependency becomes a source of ambiguity. Identity Verification may provide a valid product according to its own definition while Customer Onboarding requires something different.

A handover does not solve that difference. The product at the boundary must be explicit and evaluated against the receiving service requirements.

A recursive service architecture

When services use services, the organisational architecture becomes recursive.

A service can be examined as a complete arrangement in its own right. At the same time, its products may contribute to the results of other services, and it may depend on products provided elsewhere.

Meridian can therefore examine Customer Onboarding as one service while also opening the services on which it depends.

Identity Verification has a target group that requires reliable confirmation of identity. Its objective expresses what it seeks to achieve for that group. Its result makes that objective concrete by describing the condition in which an identity has been verified under the applicable requirements.

Its products may include registered evidence, established relations between evidence and identity, an interpretation of reliability and a verification finding.

Account Provisioning has another arrangement. Its target group requires an operational account. Its objective is to make authorised account use possible. Its result is a condition in which an authorised account is available for use. Its activities and actors are arranged around the products required to realise that condition.

Access Configuration may use the activated account as a required product within its own service. Customer Onboarding may then use both the activated account and configured access.

The same design, execution and evaluation modes can be applied repeatedly.

Each service begins with its own target group and objective. Each formulates and evaluates its own result. Each identifies the products, activities and actors it requires. Each executes its arrangement and evaluates the correspondence between what it requires and what it receives or provides.

The design and evaluation of each service can also be examined as work in its own right. This recursive application of the grammar does not add elements to the service. It changes the arrangement being examined.

Recursion does not imply that every small contribution should become a separate service.

An organisation should distinguish a service when there is a purposeful arrangement with its own target group, objective and intended result. A single activity or isolated product does not become a service merely because another service depends on it.

Identity Verification may support several services and target groups. Its verification finding may be used for onboarding, account recovery, contract formation or access renewal. This gives it a reason to be understood as a service in its own right.

By contrast, recording one field in a customer record may simply be an activity through which part of a product is formed. It does not necessarily require a separate service.

A recursive view avoids two extremes. It prevents the organisation from treating every contribution as an independent service, but it also prevents service dependencies from being hidden inside broad process descriptions.

The architecture can be opened only as far as the organisation needs. Meridian may examine Customer Onboarding as a whole when discussing the customer result. It may open Identity Verification when investigating a delay or problem in the verification finding.

The level of detail changes. The meaning of the elements and relationships does not.

Internal and external are contextual

Organisations often distinguish between internal and external services. The distinction may be useful for contracts, funding, authority or organisational design, but it does not create two different kinds of service.

Whether a service is internal or external depends on the positions of the provider and target group relative to a chosen organisational boundary.

The boundary can change.

Identity Verification may be internal to Meridian when it is provided by a Meridian unit for other Meridian services. The same service may appear external to a subsidiary, customer or partner.

Meridian may also obtain identity verification from a specialist provider. From Meridian's perspective, the service is then external. From the provider's perspective, it is part of its own service architecture and is provided to an external target group.

The service itself still requires a target group, objective, result, products, activities and actors. Its definition does not change because an organisational boundary has been crossed.

Internal and external describe context rather than essence.

This also means that outsourcing an activity does not automatically mean outsourcing a service. Meridian may engage another actor to perform one activity while Customer Onboarding remains a Meridian service. Alternatively, Meridian may use a complete service provided by another organisation.

The difference can be seen in the arrangement.

When an external actor performs an activity under Meridian's service design, the actor contributes to a Meridian product. When Meridian uses an external service, that service forms and provides its own product through its own purposeful arrangement.

Without this distinction, organisations may call every external supplier a service provider while remaining unclear about whether the supplier provides capacity, performs an activity, forms a product or operates a complete service.

Meridian clarifies its dependencies

Meridian had originally described Customer Onboarding as a process involving Customer Administration, Compliance, Information Technology and Customer Support.

The service architecture reveals a more precise arrangement.

Some required products may be formed within Customer Onboarding. Others may be provided by services that also support other parts of Meridian.

Identity Verification provides a verification finding. Account Provisioning provides an activated account. Access Configuration provides configured access. A communication service may provide the confirmation message.

Customer Onboarding does not become identical to these services. It uses their products within its own arrangement.

Meridian can now determine which service provides each product, what that product must contain, when it must be available and under which conditions it can be used.

It can also see where a problem belongs. When the verification finding is missing, Customer Onboarding cannot continue, but the missing contribution originates in Identity Verification. When the finding does not meet the onboarding requirements, the problem lies in the correspondence between the two services.

THE GRAMMAR OF WORK

This view replaces vague handovers between departments with explicit relationships between required and provided products.

Services can therefore be connected without being confused. Each service can be understood through its own arrangement, while its products connect it to the wider organisation.

9. Conclusion

Organisations do not usually struggle because work is absent. They struggle because work has been arranged and described in ways that blur the difference between services, products, activities, actors and organisational structures.

Departments are presented as services. Processes are treated as services. Broad activity labels are used as though they explain what is provided. Products and results are merged. Responsibility remains attached to areas of involvement rather than to recognisable contributions.

The consequence is not merely imprecise language.

When the elements of work are unclear, responsibilities overlap or remain incomplete. Handovers become ambiguous. Quality is discussed without agreement about what must be provided. Governance relies on measures whose meaning is uncertain. Change begins without a clear view of what is being changed.

The Grammar of Work provides a different starting point.

A service is a purposeful arrangement of six elements: target group, objective, result, products, activities and actors.

A service can also be understood through design, execution and evaluation.

All three are forms of work.

In design, actors interpret the situation of the target group, formulate objectives and results, determine requirements and form the arrangement of the service.

In execution, actors perform the required activities, form and provide products and through those products realise all or part of the intended result.

In evaluation, actors compare proposed or provided elements with the criteria that govern them and form assessments or determinations about whether they correspond.

Design begins with the target group and objective. The objective guides the intended result. The result is stated precisely enough to show what must be true for it to count as realised. This clarifies the content of Result and does not create another element. The result then determines the required products, the products determine the required activities and the activities determine the required actors.

Execution moves in the other direction. Actors perform activities, activities form products and products contribute to the result.

Evaluation can be applied throughout the arrangement. It tests whether the target group has been identified and described clearly, whether the objective addresses what matters to that group and whether the result advances the objective. It also distinguishes the internal coherence of Result, the completeness and sufficiency of the required product set and the correspondence of provided products with their requirements. It can then test whether the activities can form the required products and whether the actors can perform those activities under the stated conditions.

The centre of the service remains between product and result.

THE GRAMMAR OF WORK

A product is the direct outcome formed through activity. A result is the intended condition that the service seeks to realise for its target group.

A product realises all or part of a result. The result determines what the product must enable.

Keeping these concepts distinct makes correspondence visible. The organisation can compare what the result requires with what execution provides. It can see whether the correct product was requested, whether its requirements were clear and whether the selected activities and actors can provide it under the required conditions.

Four tests should remain distinct.

The content of Result is coherent when every stated condition is necessary and the conditions together are enough to recognise the intended state as realised.

The required product set is complete when every condition stated in Result is covered by one or more specified products and every included product contributes explicitly to Result.

The required product set is sufficient when those products, if formed and provided as specified, can collectively make the complete result true.

Correspondence in execution exists when the products actually formed and provided meet their requirements and can contribute as intended to Result.

A result formulation can be defective even when a product set has been specified. A product set can be incomplete or insufficient even when execution is flawless. A correctly specified product can still be formed incorrectly. Keeping these failures separate makes diagnosis and responsibility more precise.

The same arrangement clarifies responsibility. Design actors can be connected to the descriptions, objectives, results, requirements and arrangements they formulate. Execution actors can be connected to the activities they perform and products they form. Evaluation actors can be connected to the assessments and determinations they provide.

The products of design and evaluation belong to the work through which the service is arranged and assessed. They are not automatically products delivered by the operational service to its target group. The same grammar is being applied to a different arrangement.

Services may also use products provided by other services. This allows services to be connected without being confused. Dependencies can be examined through the products that cross their boundaries.

Meridian's Customer Onboarding service shows how the approach moves from target group and objective to an explicit result, required products, activities and actors. The example also shows how evaluation can identify whether the result, product set, execution and responsibility correspond.

The sequence matters.

An organisation cannot create coherence by adding governance to an ambiguous arrangement. It cannot obtain reliable insight from categories whose meaning is unclear. Measures, controls and responsibilities become useful only when the organisation first knows what is required, what is provided, how it is formed and what it is intended to realise.

Insight and governance do not create coherence. They become possible when the service itself has been arranged coherently.

This paper describes how a service arrangement is formed and examined. The grounds, authority and applicability of its objectives and criteria remain part of the governance arrangements that ground it.

THE GRAMMAR OF WORK

Once that arrangement is explicit, the organisation can see whether products correspond with results, whether activities are necessary, whether actors are suitable, whether responsibilities are complete and whether service dependencies are properly defined.

It can identify gaps, overlaps and unnecessary work without reducing the organisation to one process or forcing every service into one organisational structure.

The grammar applies to its own use. Designing a service, executing it and evaluating it are all forms of work performed by actors through activities that form recognisable products. The service architecture therefore does not stand outside the work it describes.

The Grammar of Work provides more than a vocabulary. It provides a way to arrange work so that its meaning remains clear.

A service is a purposeful arrangement in which actors perform activities, form and provide one or more products, and through those products realise a result for a target group.

When that arrangement is explicit, the organisation can describe its services clearly, govern them consistently and change them deliberately.